more marked as the Burmese Road to Socialism failed as an economic doctrine and the regime looked for a new approach to shore up its popular appeal.

Nevertheless, in both 1988–90 and 2007–8 Buddhist monks played a critical role in the popular protests against the regime. In this respect, Buddhism can be argued to have played a positive role in forcing the transition from military rule towards democracy in the period 1988–2010. By joining the student revolts, the monks gave them wider credibility, provided the NLD with the mass movement they sought, and indicated that the regime was losing control of the country—certainly, they brought a great deal of moral authority to the revolt. Many monks were imprisoned or killed[46] as a result of their involvement, which constituted a further reason why the reputation of the military and the USDP suffered after the protests.

But for Myanmar's non-Burman, non-Buddhist minorities, the alliance between the monks and the NLD was not so positive. There are, of course, significant exceptions. Some monks have visited the Kachin regions and sought to work with the largely Christian community there. One monk walked across Rakhine in support of peace and reconciliation,[47] and in 2014 monks also supported local people protesting against mining and forced land evictions.

However, the link between the NLD and the Buddhist monks could hinder Myanmar's development. The ideological leaders of the persecution of the Rohingyas come from among the monks, and they may put pressure on the NLD to link Burmese citizenship to Buddhism.

The influence of the extremist monks is also one of the many reasons why the military remains complicit in anti-Rohingya violence. Attacking the Rohingyas is something the religious extremists, the military, and even some members of the NLD can all agree on.[48] As 'protectors of the nation',[49] joining in such attacks is one way that the military can demonstrate that they are in tune with religious sentiments and thus gain Buddhist support for their rule. Thus attacking the Rohingyas has become, to some, a public way to emphasise one's commitment to Buddhism. Also, as indicated earlier, some degree of civil unrest may be welcome to the military—it provides a pretext for their retention of power and even, if needed, grounds for a military coup[50] if they are in danger of losing power over the current democratic structures.